사과의 단계: 누구에게, 어떻게 사과해요?

This worksheet shows how Korean apologies change from casual to formal, and how a full apology is built.

WHAT THIS IS FOR

You can choose an apology that fits the person and the situation, put a full apology in order, and find the key information in an apology notice.

1 APOLOGY LEVELS: 미안해 → 사과드립니다

1. **미안해** (sorry (casual))
   Use it with close friends, younger siblings, or people younger than you.
   예: 늦어서 미안해. 길이 많이 막혔어.
2. **미안해요** (sorry (polite))
   Use it with people of about the same age who you are not very close to.
   예: 어, 제 자리인 줄 알았어요. 미안해요.
3. **죄송해요** (I'm sorry (respectful))
   Use it with older people, teachers, and strangers.
   예: 선생님, 숙제를 아직 못 했어요. 죄송해요.
4. **죄송합니다** (I'm sorry (formal))
   Use it at work, with customers, and in public.
   예: 회의에 늦어서 죄송합니다.
5. **잘못했어요** (I was wrong)
   Use it to clearly admit that the fault is yours.
   예: 제가 잘못했어요. 다시는 안 그럴게요.
6. **실례합니다** (excuse me)
   Say it before you bother someone, not after a mistake.
   예: 실례합니다. 잠깐만 지나갈게요.
7. **양해 부탁드립니다** (please understand)
   Used in notices to ask people to accept a problem for a while.
   예: 공사 중입니다. 양해 부탁드립니다.
8. **괜찮아요 / 괜찮아** (it's okay)
   Say this to accept an apology. Use 괜찮아 with friends.
   예: 괜찮아요. 저도 방금 왔어요.

2 A FULL APOLOGY, STEP BY STEP

1. **사과하기** (say sorry first)
2. **무슨 일인지 말하기** (say what happened)
3. **잘못 인정하기** (admit your fault)
4. **해결하기** (offer to fix it)
5. **약속하기** (promise it won't happen again)

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3 TIPS: KOREAN 'SORRY' VS. ENGLISH 'SORRY'

In English, 'I'm sorry' can show sympathy, as in 'I'm sorry to hear that.' In Korean, 미안해요 and 죄송해요 mean you did something wrong. When you hear sad news, say 많이 힘드시겠어요 instead.

The notice in the exercises is a typical apartment notice written for practice. It is not from a real building.

4 YOUR TURN

CHOOSE, ORDER, AND ANSWER
Use the apology levels, the apology steps, and the tips above to answer each question.

1. Choose the right expression for each situation:
①회사에서 부장님께 회의 자료를 늦게 드렸어요. (미안해 / 죄송합니다)
②동생 과자를 말없이 다 먹었어요. (미안해 / 죄송합니다)
③좁은 식당에서 다른 손님 뒤를 지나가야 해요. (실례합니다 / 잘못했어요)

2. Put the server's apology in the right order:
(가) 바로 다시 만들어 드리겠습니다. (나) 정말 죄송합니다. (다) 주문하신 것과 다른 음식이 나갔네요. (라) 앞으로 더 주의하겠습니다.

3. Read the notice and answer:
[안내] 엘리베이터 점검으로 오늘 오후 2시부터 4시까지 엘리베이터를 사용할 수 없습니다. 이용에 불편을 드려 죄송합니다. 주민 여러분의 양해를 부탁드립니다.
①Why is the building apologizing?
②Copy the sentence that asks residents for understanding.

4. Answer in Korean, in casual speech: Your friend says, "어제 전화 못 받아서 미안해." Tell your friend it's okay.

5. Yes or No: Your coworker tells you her grandmother passed away. Should you answer, "죄송해요"?

ANSWERS

1) ① 죄송합니다 ② 미안해 ③ 실례합니다
2) (나) → (다) → (가) → (라)
3) ① The elevator is being checked, so it can't be used from 2 to 4 p.m. today. ② 주민 여러분의 양해를 부탁드립니다.
4) 괜찮아. (아니야, 괜찮아.)
5) No. 죄송해요 means you did something wrong. Say something like 많이 힘드시겠어요.

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